The Jesuits noted the keen and incisive manner with which Akbar was able to deal with a variety of subjects. ‘He can give his opinion on any question so shrewdly and keenly,’ wrote Monserrate, ‘that no one who did not know that he is illiterate would suppose him to be anything but very learned and erudite. And so indeed he is, for in addition to his keen intellect, of which I have already spoken, he excels many of his most learned subjects in eloquence, as well as in that authority and dignity which befits a King.’ Akbar’s clerks carefully noted down everything he said and all the while, ‘skillful gladiators and wrestlers from all countries hold themselves in readiness, and singers, male and female, are in waiting. Clever jugglers and funny tumblers also are anxious to exhibit their dexterity and agility.’

If the entertainment was to be music, then there was a great deal of choice for there were a variety of artists, ‘Hindus, Iranis, Turanis, Kashmiris, both men and women’, organized in a rotating system for each day of the week. By studying the miniatures painted at this time, scholars have concluded that of the musical instruments, one of the most popular was the Hindustani veena. There was also a Persian flute called the na’i, the Hindustani flute, several types of lutes, a harp, as well as percussion instruments. Of all the musicians, the most revered of them all was Tansen, still at court and still singing his haunting Dhrupad compositions. ‘A singer like him,’ wrote Abu’l Fazl confidently, ‘has not been seen in India for the last thousand years.’ Tansen was not just a singer, but also a poet-composer, and wrote his lyrics in Brajbhasha. ‘The fact that Akbar patronized him and others like him,’ writes music historian Françoise Delvoye, ‘suggests that the Emperor was familiar with the vernacular languages in which the song-texts were composed and could appreciate [their] imagery and aesthetic values, which were quite different from those of Persian poetry.’ And there is, in fact, a rich oral tradition of Akbar being enthralled by Tansen’s singing a song that he thought the maestro had composed, only to discover that the Brajbhasha song he was singing was composed by a Bhakti poet. A popular incident involved the poetess Pravin Ray, a courtesan of great beauty at the court of Raja Indrajit of Orchha, and a student of the poet Keshavdas[*]. Hearing of her beauty and talent, Akbar summoned her to court upon which she sent him a proud retort:

Pay heed, wise emperor, to what Pravin Ray has to say.
Only low-caste people, cows and dogs eat off plates used by others.